

No Diggety: Black Masculinity and the Drag King Act Two black drag kings who did find their way into regular drag king performances from the HerShe Bar contests are Shon and Dred, who often perform together. Shon, twenty-nine, and Dred, twenty-five, have a wide range of performances; while Dred's signature act is a mackdaddy from the disco era, Shon is stunning as a hot, crotch-grabbing rapper (fig. 3). Shon and Dred both won HerShe Bar contests and went on to compete in the final showdown against each other. Shon remembers seeing Dred in an early contest: "I said she's definitely gonna win, she's got it! She was excellent. I liked the name, I liked the presence, and I could tell she was good. As a performer myself, I always look for true dramatic talent."²⁸ Dred thinks Shon is a "smooth" drag king, and she remembers seeing Shon as her major competition in the Grand Finale contest; ultimately, the contest came down to the two of them, and it was Dred who walked away with the title. In the earlier contest that she won, Shon recalls that she was asked to answer a question on stage. The question was "What does it mean to you to be a drag king?" And Shon answered, "It means showing men and women how women should be treated." This answer is very much in keeping with Shon's smooth drag king persona, and it won her plenty of fan support. Shon noticed that more women of color entered the contests as time went on, but she also noted that many of these women did not dress up in drag: "They went up with what they had, rather than in drag; they might be boyish naturally or just butch-looking." Both Shon and Dred comment on the dearth of women of color who are interested in becoming drag kings. In a Jackson Five act that Dred and Shon put together, for example, they had to use men for some of the roles. They have a hard time explaining why more women of color do not get involved; but both are confident that as time goes on and as drag king popularity grows, more women of color will develop stage drag king acts. In their shows, Dred and Shon mix up the music and the style that each of them favors. In their fifteen-minute "R'n'B Old School Show" that they performed at HerShe Bar to an audience of screaming women, they included rap songs by Run DMC and did the duet "You're All I Need" by Method Man and Mary J. Blige. They also performed a hot and flashy rendition of "No Diggety" by Blackstreet, which actually reproduced the scenes of screaming female fan response that usually accompany live performances by Blackstreet. Dred and Shon's show is an extremely entertaining combination of male impersonation, perfectly timed lip-synching, and choreographed dance moves. They manage to pull off close replications of the performers they imitate, and in many of their shows parody gives way to homage. If many of the white drag kings poke gentle fun at white masculinity, Dred Judith Halberstam